

Lesson 7: Slowing Down to Interact with Fans

Alexis Hornbuckle

Coach Summitt was a big influence in my life, and it wasn't just because she was strict and I told my dad the reason I wanted to go to Tennessee, this lady's crazy. She'll keep me in check. But beyond that, she was probably one of the most compassionate, nicest, motherly individuals you could ever meet. As college kids, you're just that, you're kids, who your parents entrust in the coach's hands. And she made sure to treat us all like her daughters.

I mean, cookouts. By the way, Coach Summitt could throw down in the kitchen. That lady could cook her butt off, okay? And that just made it even better. That nice home-cooked meal served with a smile and making sure that everybody was well taken care of. Pat didn't miss a beat with that. When it came to the kids or the fans, she's signing every single autograph that she possibly can. She's taking every single picture that she possibly can. That's just to be who she was of her stature and to leave the legacy that she left. Even while she was alive and coaching, her legacy was already built.

So to see someone like that who doesn't have to stop for photos, who doesn't have to stop for autographs, who doesn't have to stop just to have a conversation with the janitor, she was exactly that person. And I could tell you, it doesn't matter how big you get as an athlete, as a coach, as a leader, take the time. Take the time to just put a smile on someone's face and make their day.

Coach used to be big on open door policy. I'm going to speak to everybody and everybody can speak to me. That is huge. Today it's a whole lot of egos, a whole lot of pride in a lot of positions. Coach wasn't that. And that woman won eight national championships. And she's legendary. I take note if I were you.